

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 5: Chetna Gala Sinha, Mann Deshi Foundation

Neharika Vohra: Welcome, viewers, to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad. In this podcast, we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Chetna Gala Sinha, social activist, rural development leader, and one of India's most remarkable grassroots entrepreneurs. Chetna founded Mann Deshi Mahila Sahakari Bank in 1997, the first bank in India licensed to operate for and by rural women, and has since built the Mann Deshi Foundation into a nationally celebrated institution, empowering women entrepreneurs in drought-prone, semi-arid rural Maharashtra — perhaps the most difficult terrain to work in. Growing up with a deep commitment to social justice, Chetna has worked at the intersection of rural finance, women's livelihoods, education and sports. Mann Deshi Foundation has reached over five lakh women across Maharashtra through its banking, business school, mobile business school, radio station and sports programmes. Chetna has been awarded the Nari Shakti Puraskar, India's highest civilian award for women working in women's empowerment, and received the Forbes India Leadership Award for entrepreneurship with social impact.

Neharika Vohra: Chetna Gala Sinha, welcome — we are very, very happy to have you for this podcast. It is indeed a privilege and an honour to have you here. Thank you.

Chetna Sinha: Thank you so much, Neharika, and thank you for inviting me to this podcast, which I understand is run as a special programme in someone's memory. I'll be delighted to share my experiences, my journey, alongside some very wise leaders — and I've learned so much from these women myself. Thank you.

Neharika Vohra: Chetna, could you give us a picture of what Mann Deshi looks like today — its scale, the range of issues it addresses, the geographies it operates in, and the nature of its membership and workforce?

Chetna Sinha: Thank you again for inviting me — I'm delighted to share my journey, particularly with these women, spanning nearly three decades now, and the lessons I've learned from them. Today, both Mann Deshi Foundation and Mann Deshi Bank exist. The Foundation works with women on financial inclusion, women and sports, women and health, girls and sports, and with women farmers on soil health — it started as an entrepreneurship programme, but has since grown into a broader women's and community organisation. The Foundation operates in Maharashtra, Gujarat and Chhattisgarh — across nearly 22 locations, particularly in Maharashtra — while Mann Deshi Bank operates within Maharashtra itself. The bank provides not just access to finance, but real control over finance — savings, credit — as a cooperative bank. So the model is that the bank handles financial inclusion, control and access, while the Foundation builds capacity and capability, and creates the networks through which women can own assets and even own brands themselves.

I'm proud to share that across all three states, Mann Deshi Bank and Foundation together impacted one million women entrepreneurs last year, who have collectively created five million jobs. And it isn't only about entrepreneurship — our women farmers have started one of India's genuinely unique programmes, though I hope it stops being unique and spreads everywhere: work on enriching soil, and enriching it with water, while reducing the abuse of fertilisers and pesticides. We have an agriculture centre and a water-testing centre for farmers, and Mann Deshi provides all of this at people's doorstep — because life in India's villages is fragmented, and our whole approach is to go to people, through bank sakhis, soil sakhis, health sakhis, digital didis, and design solutions collectively with their own intelligence, combined with technology and science, in ways that improve their lives while conserving the ecology they care about.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. And so many of the women who work with you also come from the community itself. What proportion are from the community, and what proportion are professionally trained staff?

Chetna Sinha: In Mann Deshi Foundation, essentially all of our staff — well over 100% in spirit — come from the local community. The reason is simple: we're not based in a metro city; our main office isn't even at a taluka headquarters — it's a large village, really. Nobody from Mumbai is coming to relocate and work here, so all our staff are local, and we train them ourselves. Mann Deshi Bank has a team of 80 people, and the Foundation has more than 460 team members, so altogether we're around 540 people, including community leaders and founders of farmer-producer companies, operating across nearly 800 villages.

Neharika Vohra: That's such an amazing spread. It would be wonderful for our audience to understand your own journey — from setting up the rural bank to branching out into pretty much everything that helps women take charge of their own lives.

Chetna Sinha: It's interesting you ask, because as you were speaking, I found myself thinking that 35 years ago, I never imagined I'd be sitting here in Mhaswad doing a Zoom call with you. I was born and raised in Mumbai — Bombay, at the time — and I was very much a Mumbai girl: cricket, Bollywood, the local trains, life moving fast every single day. During my undergraduate years, before I'd even graduated, I was quite active in student politics, and this was the period when Jayaprakash Narayan's movement began — you're in Gujarat, so you'll know how much of that started there too. JP came to Mumbai University and appealed to young students, saying real India lives in its villages, and that if we wanted to serve the country, we should go and work there. I was genuinely fascinated by that idea, and told him directly that I wanted to work in India's villages. He said, of course — join an organisation, then go. I wasn't even 21 at the time, and I got the chance to travel across the Indian countryside — Bihar, the Northeast — working alongside youth wherever these organisations had a presence.

All this while, I kept thinking I was simply doing my graduation, planning a post-graduate degree in economics, which I eventually completed at Mumbai University. But through all that travel, I realised how much I'd actually learned, and that I wanted to work in villages, even though I hadn't yet committed to it. Then, one time, I came to a very drought-prone part of Maharashtra — this very place, Mhaswad, where I'm sitting now. There was a movement here for higher wages; this was before MGNREGA, when Maharashtra had its own Employment Guarantee Scheme. People were working under it because the drought was so severe — no jobs, no crops in the fields, no water, and the men had migrated out. Women were asking for work simply to survive, and the work they were given was road construction and stone-breaking. I arrived in the month of May, nearly 48 degrees Celsius, and I saw women breaking stone in that heat, some with toddlers strapped to them, feeding the children and going right back to work. I couldn't fathom it — this felt like work fit for a life sentence, not something any human being should have to do. That stayed with me. I ended up staying there about eight days, and decided I wanted to work with these women — I didn't know how we'd change their lives, but I felt we'd find some solutions along the way.

Around the same time, Vijay Sinha, who was organising labourers in the area and later became my husband — I fell in love with him, feeling he'd taken up such a noble cause — and we decided to marry. After a year teaching economics in Mumbai, I left that job and moved to Mhaswad to start working. It was interesting, because at that young age you wake up every day with energy, ready to plan your whole day the way you would in Mumbai — except I had no resources at all; we did everything on bicycle, going from village to village. Whenever I met women and talked to them, I noticed something: they'd never simply demand things. Instead they'd tell me, you're so young, you should go back, study, or at most have lunch with us and then return to the city — why would you stay here? This is our destiny, we'll take care of our own lives.

Neharika Vohra: Very interesting.

Chetna Sinha: But they'd talk about opportunity — there was no connectivity, no electricity, no water, and these women had never been to school. Many told me: we're doing our small businesses on the street, but we want some kind of shelter. When I asked what they wanted to do about it, they said they wanted to save — save enough to buy a big umbrella, or a thick cotton sheet for shelter, because they had no house to stay in either; they did their business there, cooked there, slept there. I told them, if you want to save, you should go to the banks. They said, we already tried, but the banks wouldn't open our accounts. So I said, I'll come with you. I went with them to the bank myself and said, you should open their accounts — they want to save. The bank manager said saving three rupees a day wasn't practically viable for the bank, and that nobody was going to visit them daily to collect three rupees. I pointed out they weren't even asking for a loan or a subsidy — just to save. When the banks refused, I told the women, let's go straight to the Reserve Bank of India and apply for a banking licence ourselves.

I went to Mumbai, to the RBI, and explained our situation — our women wanted to start a bank because existing banks wouldn't serve them. Fortunately, there was a window open at the time for cooperative banking licences specifically for women, tribal communities and youth, following a committee report the RBI itself had commissioned to look into financial exclusion of exactly these groups. I gathered all the information, studied how to apply, and went directly to RBI officers myself — I had no idea professionals typically prepared these proposals. I came back, sat with the women, and together we prepared a proposal, meeting whatever capital and membership requirements were needed. When I went back to submit it, the officer told me they couldn't even accept the proposal, because our promoting members were non-literate, and there was no precedent for that. I came back nervous, telling the women we couldn't even submit the proposal because of our non-literacy. They simply said, why are you so nervous — we'll learn to read and write. So what? And our literacy classes began, run by local women themselves going village to village. I wasn't even sure it would lead anywhere, but I thought, at least there's no harm in people learning to read and write.

After five months, we applied again — and this time I didn't go alone, because I thought we might still be refused, and I wanted the women to face that "no" directly with me if it came. Fifteen women accompanied me to the Reserve Bank of India. When we got there, I honestly wasn't sure what they'd say — but they told the officer plainly: you denied us the licence because we can't read and write, but there were no schools in our villages when we were growing up, so we're not responsible for that. And they said: we may not be able to read and write, but we can count. That was an incredibly powerful statement, and a real lesson for me. They told the officer: ask us to calculate the interest on any principal amount — if we fail, don't issue the licence, but have your officers do the same calculation without a calculator, and see who's faster. These were women who had come to the Reserve Bank of India for the very first time in their lives.

We came back not knowing what would happen — we'd had a good meeting, but I didn't want to give the women false hope. Then, after five months, I got a message through the postal department — this was before mobile phones, when long-distance calls went through trunk lines — saying the Reserve Bank of India had been trying to reach me for two days. I went to the post office at the appointed time and got the call: an RBI official told me, Mrs Sinha, you didn't even follow up, but we've already dispatched the licence — this is the very first one we're issuing this way, and a compendium is on its way too, so read it and operate the bank accordingly. It was such a surprise. The bank started in 1997; the Foundation had actually begun a year earlier, in 1996. And throughout, it was the women themselves who'd say, of course we can manage this — we can't read and write, but we can count and manage finance perfectly well.

Neharika Vohra: What an amazing story — and credit to that RBI officer too, for doing the right thing, and to the women for their confidence, and to you for stewarding the whole process. Thank you for sharing that. Today you sit at the intersection of rural finance, women's enterprise, education and sport, and much of that likely depends on donors, government, and banking regulators — all of whom probably pull you in different directions at times. How have you managed that, and what have been some key lessons?

Chetna Sinha: When we got the banking licence, I came in with an urban mindset — ideas I'd absorbed from books, and from watching how banks operated in a big city. I was excited to build something along those lines. Meanwhile, the women were thinking about the bank in a completely different way, which I only realised much later — for them, it was fundamentally about savings, and keeping their money safe and secure.

When we set up the bank, right from the search for office space, nobody believed we'd actually gotten the licence — there were MPs who'd tried and failed, so nobody thought we'd manage it, and nobody wanted to rent us space, questioning how we'd even pay rent. When we were finally choosing a location, the women were remarkably sharp about it — I suggested somewhere in the middle of the market for convenience, and they said yes, but insisted on a second door at the back too. When I asked why — thinking it was purely about security — they explained: when we come to the bank to save, people notice, and they'll tell our husbands and families that we're saving money somewhere. We don't want that. Part of why they wanted a bank at all was to keep their savings safe from being spent by family members, particularly — at the time — on alcohol, which has since reduced but was a real issue. That's when I understood they weren't thinking of the bank as a service; they saw it as an institution that gave them control over their own finances. Everything about it wasn't about access for them — it was about control. So we designed the branch with two doors.

Even designing our savings product, my own education and assumptions nearly worked against us. I assumed these women would only ever have very small, irregular amounts to save, and that we couldn't visit daily, so we designed a savings box with a Mickey Mouse design on it — the idea being that once the box filled up, we'd transfer the money into their bank account. We ordered 7,000 boxes for our first distribution. About two weeks later, one woman came to me furious, holding a broken box, demanding to know whose idea this had been. Before our representative had come to collect and transfer the money, her husband had broken the box open and taken everything. That was when I realised I couldn't afford to be careless with people's lives — the design of any product, whether savings, credit or pension, has to account for real processes on the ground: do they even want to step inside a bank branch, or do they need the bank to come to them? We began forming a team of community leaders to consult before launching any new product, because the whole point of the institution was that people should have control over their own assets and finances — a product that undermines that simply doesn't make sense. Today, nearly 30 years in, Mann Deshi is the first bank to offer overdraft and cash-credit facilities to weekly-market street vendors, precisely because rural, grassroots life is fragmented — cash flows are irregular, disasters strike without warning, so everything needs to be flexible and available at the doorstep. We have agents moving through communities with savings and credit facilities.

Beyond banking, women kept telling us: this is all wonderful, but we want to grow our income — how do we scale our vegetable business, manage our finances better? So we started thinking about a business school for rural women — a "Deshi MBA," designed entirely for women who'd never been to school, using pictures and now films, teaching things like diversifying a

household's income sources systematically — say, combining a small goat farm with growing vegetables, where the vegetable scraps feed the goats. Women could enrol for a full year and think through how to scale their business or get a bigger loan.

Microcredit, while hugely successful, also brought its own fallout, including real debt problems, which pushed us to keep strengthening the business school. One woman, Saraswati, ran a business selling vegetables and snacks, and had bought a tempo to scale up — but easy multi-source lending pulled her into serious debt, and her husband disappeared. She came to the bank herself and said, quite courageously, I've defaulted, and I can't pay my installment because I don't know where my husband has gone. My initial reaction, from a purely banking mindset, was that we couldn't afford an NPA and she had to repay — but I quickly realised how lucky we were that she'd come to us directly, telling us the truth instead of simply disappearing. We heard her out, then worked out how many lenders she owed, negotiated write-downs and renewed terms — practical solutions. But that experience taught us we needed something more systematic: debt counselling as part of our financial literacy work, especially for first-generation entrepreneurs, who don't have the same legal protections wealthier borrowers do when they default.

Climate impact fell hardest on exactly these communities — farm labourers, street vendors, people working entirely in the open. In the severe 2012 drought, we saw many women coming to mortgage their gold. One woman, Kerabai, came in to mortgage gold to buy fodder for her animals — she explained that if her animals died, that was the last thing tying her to the village; without them, she'd end up in a city slum. She could mortgage gold for fodder, she said, but she couldn't buy water. Her name, Kerabai, meaning "waste" — she was her father's sixth daughter, married off to a man who already had one wife. That contrast — such hardship alongside such clarity — stayed with me deeply. Part of me, the banker, was thinking about balance sheets and focus; the other part was asking, who did we start this bank for in the first place — the balance sheet, or people? The bank itself couldn't solve this, so the Foundation started a cattle camp. Within eight days, 7,000 farmers arrived with 14,000 animals. That year it never rained, so the camp ran for a full year, eventually with government support. We realised the Foundation needed to work on water directly — reviving dried-up rivers with expert-designed water banks to conserve water — and from there the Foundation's agriculture centre grew too.

Working with farmers taught us something important: their families aren't only human. As Kerabai put it, her animals were part of her family, her trees were part of her family — the whole framing is different. During the cattle camp, one woman, Parvati, walked five hours from her home in the heat with five animals, and when she arrived, our staff wanted her to complete registration paperwork first. She said, let me feed my animal water first — do the paperwork after. Our manager worried we'd lose track of her among so many farmers, but my husband Vijay, who was there, pointed out — she's telling you clearly what matters, why are we resisting? Once she'd fed her animals, she told us plainly: you're asking me for photo IDs and papers, but you don't understand that these animals have fed milk to this whole country, and nobody asks them for ID before they give milk. That native wisdom is something we routinely fail to understand — and it reshaped how our agriculture programmes are designed now, treating soil itself as something alive, giving communities the science and technology to make their own decisions about enriching it, which is how the Soil Sakhi programme and our agriculture and water testing centre came about.

There's enormous talent in these communities that has nothing to do with formal schooling. This whole area has nomadic shepherd communities, and young girls here herd sheep and goats from a very young age, alongside going to school — and in doing so, they build extraordinary physical strength. We noticed this directly: in 2005, a girl named Parvati, having just finished seventh standard, came to us wanting to continue studying, but her high school was in a bigger town with no transport. She offered to work at the bank for two months during her vacation, asking for no pay — just a bicycle at the end, so she could get to school; without it, her parents would pull her out. It seemed such a simple, obvious solution. We started giving loans for bicycles, and eventually found generous donors who simply gave bicycles outright. Today, 14,000 girls have received bicycles to get to school. And these girls, already strong from herding animals or cycling long distances, started showing real athletic talent — which is how our sports programme began. We built a 400-metre athletics ground, now a proper stadium, inaugurated by Sachin Tendulkar — though the real stars were always the girls themselves. Kajal, whose parents cut sugarcane for a living, now plays field hockey for India and won a silver medal in Iceland.

I'm blessed to be surrounded by people I keep learning from — and from all this, we've built a sports academy, health centre, bank, Deshi MBA school, and now Shetty Shalas and labs for farmers, including water testing.

Neharika Vohra: What an amazing set of programmes — and what I also hear is how responsive you've been to what you actually heard from the people you work with, learning from them rather than imposing solutions. You've mentioned philanthropists and government funding too — how have you managed to attract that kind of support?

Chetna Sinha: That support journey was interesting in itself. It really began around our bicycle programme, when it got picked up in the press — this was around 2005-06, long before CSR as we know it today existed, and we were a tiny, remote location that nobody knew about. Around the same time, two things happened. First, we entered a business school competition run by an

MIT hub — we didn't win, but they gave us special recognition, and that generated some attention. Then a story about the bicycle programme for girls appeared in an English newspaper, and funders started reaching out — HSBC was actually the first to visit and see what we were doing. That's really how it started. I realised then that I needed to actively engage funders too, though honestly, before that, I'd been quite content simply doing the work and learning from it.

At the same time, we also needed real talent support from outside — for instance, when digitisation began. Even before that, we ran into an interesting problem: many women were keeping their passbooks at the bank rather than taking them home, precisely because they didn't want family members to see their savings. That told us the bank itself couldn't hold that information visibly either — women needed something private. So we thought about a smart passbook — this was around 2007, before digital banking had properly started in India. Coincidentally, I'd been invited to speak at Harvard and MIT, where I described this idea, and a student from Tufts came to work with us on a solution — a chip-based passbook you could swipe to read and update. Women loved it, since they could carry it home without anyone else seeing their balance. So when full digital banking eventually arrived, our women were already prepared. When we introduced ATM cards requiring PIN numbers, the women pushed back — not because they couldn't remember a PIN, but because they wanted something else entirely: biometric authentication, using their thumbprint. Suppliers said it would be difficult, but the women insisted, so we found the technology. Once they started using biometric withdrawal, they told us plainly: nobody can steal my thumb. That was the moment I truly understood something important — never give poor solutions to poor people; they are smart, and you have to listen to them. They later asked for voice SMS balance alerts too, well before that became standard — and in some cases, the industry actually learned from what our women were asking for first.

I've come to love sharing these stories because there's so much wisdom here. It became something of a personal practice — whenever I'm invited to speak somewhere, I go and talk to our women first, asking what they think I should say, because they've genuinely become my guide. When I was invited to co-chair at Davos, at the World Economic Forum in 2018, alongside people like Christine Lagarde and the President of Norway, I realised I'd likely be the only voice from the Global South in that room. Before going, I asked our women what I should say — knowing everyone there would be talking about billions and trillions of capital. They told me: tell them our courage is our capital. I found that such a clear, powerful answer — being courageous is genuinely harder than raising capital; it takes something much deeper. I told them afterward: you said our courage is our capital, but really, your courage has become my capital — I became courageous because of you. I always tell people it's been a genuine blessing to be surrounded by these women, who've made me courageous in turn.

Neharika Vohra: So powerful. How does the financial model work overall?

Chetna Sinha: At the institutional level, the bank runs entirely without outside support — it's the first rural cooperative bank funded purely by member capital, member savings and member credit, with a mixed business of around 400 crore rupees. The Foundation, on the other hand, is supported by philanthropic grants and, more recently, CSR funding — the business school, chamber of commerce, agriculture centre and sports academy are all run and supported through the Foundation. The bank's team are salaried bank employees, and the bank itself is profitable — we distribute dividends periodically, or, at our women's own request, redirect a portion of profits, roughly 35%, toward things like agriculture support, within regulatory limits. Personally, given how much I now travel and speak, I'm able to sustain myself through speaking fees.

Neharika Vohra: Wonderful. In any organisation, there are always challenges around attracting, retaining and motivating people. Is there anything special about how you've approached that?

Chetna Sinha: Getting the right people has always been genuinely challenging — we're not in a metro city, there's no Mumbai here. For our first ten years, we relied entirely on local talent, training them ourselves, including directly with the Reserve Bank of India on agricultural banking. One recurring issue with hiring young women is that many marry and move to their in-laws' place, and we lose them. But I've always believed the work culture itself needs to be joyful — I never feel like leaving our women; being with them, talking with them, absorbing their wisdom, keeps it that way. Because of that, many young women who joined us while still unmarried actually chose to marry within the geographies where the Foundation or bank operates, or found genuinely considerate husbands willing to relocate to support their work here. That said, we do face a real challenge once children reach school age and families want to move to bigger towns for education.

This isn't unique to our staff — it's true of women entrepreneurs generally. Men build networks from childhood, wherever they grow up; women typically marry into a new place and only start building their own networks afterward, losing years in the process. So we tell our women entrepreneurs explicitly: networking matters enormously for women, precisely because of this asymmetry. Every woman, in a sense, migrates. What helps is encouraging women to think of Mann Deshi as their maika — their natal home — and to stay connected to it as a bridge back to their own roots.

Neharika Vohra: Is most of your workforce made up of women?

Chetna Sinha: It used to be entirely women, though we've since been questioned on diversity grounds. In the Foundation, men make up less than 5% of staff; in the bank, closer to 9%. Our leadership positions are reserved for women — branch managers, credit officers, recovery officers, audit officers, the roles with real decision-making power, are never given to men.

Neharika Vohra: Is that because women bring more empathy when serving other women as customers, tied to the organisation's mission?

Chetna Sinha: The mission is certainly part of it, but I also believe women bring a genuinely different perspective — more empathetic, more attuned in ways that matter here.

Neharika Vohra: Turning to you personally — who have your mentors been, and how have you stayed connected to a wider network of leaders while doing this work?

Chetna Sinha: Leaving Mumbai for Mhaswad was a genuinely drastic decision — seven hours away, an entirely different life. We had no access to English newspapers, and I couldn't read Marathi at all, so staying connected to the wider world took real effort — I remember writing to Shekhar Gupta, editor of the Indian Express at the time, and to the editor of Business India, simply asking if they could post us copies, even late editions, because we had no access at all. I felt genuinely far from the mainstream world in that period. But at the same time, I began meeting women whose values and thinking came not from books, but from lived experience.

One memory stands out — during our 18-month cattle camp, we held a flag-hoisting ceremony on 15th August. Afterward, one woman came up to me, visibly moved, and said she'd never been to school, never before saluted the flag or sung the national anthem — this was her first time doing either, in her entire life. I realised then that everything I'd learned about nationhood from books felt shallow next to the depth of what I was hearing directly from these communities. That's when I started feeling genuinely content here, that I was learning far more from these women than I ever could elsewhere — and honestly, I remain almost greedy for these lessons even now.

My mother-in-law was another such figure — an independent, strong woman, though from a very traditional background, widowed young. I never wore a mangalsutra or any of the traditional symbols, and she'd tell me I should, and I'd push back, asking her, given everything was taken from you when you were widowed, how can you defend these rituals? She'd say, whatever you're saying may be right, but these are simply the rituals. She had her own gentle way of keeping me grounded — once, coming back from a year at Yale, I brought home some cheese, something we'd never had before, and she looked at it and said, so you've brought back this plastic from America. It wasn't really about the cheese — it was her way of saying, don't bring back some borrowed wisdom and abandon what's already here.

That same grounding came through women like Kerabai, whom I mentioned earlier — she went on to become a radio jockey. During the cattle camp, she started singing to give farmers hope for rain, composing her own poems despite never having gone to school, and became genuinely popular — eventually hosting her own radio programme and becoming known as "Radio Jockey Kerabai." Rakesh Anand Bakshi, son of the lyricist Anand Bakshi, was writing a book on radio jockeys and asked to interview her — he asked how she'd learned to sing. She told him: I was married at 13, as my father's sixth daughter, named Kera — meaning waste — because everyone simply wanted me out of the house. I became pregnant at 14, and I was constantly hungry, so I started singing just to forget the hunger. Talent surfaces from the most unlikely places in these villages.

That whole way of seeing things shaped how I raised my own children too — I never felt the pull to send them to school in Mumbai. I felt they'd learn more here — climbing trees, swimming in lakes, seeing entire ecosystems, even hyenas, which we used to have more of. My son and my twins studied locally, in Marathi medium, through school, before going to bigger cities for higher studies. I like telling young people they didn't miss anything by not being in an English-medium school in Mumbai, ferried between tuitions — all three of my children went on to study at places like Georgetown, George Washington and the London School of Music. I think we often overlook the wisdom and richness already available around us — not just human wisdom, but the whole living world: animals, trees, an entire ecosystem that speaks, if you're willing to listen.

Neharika Vohra: As we move toward closing, a couple of important questions remain. What does succession look like at Mann Deshi, both bank and Foundation? While I wish you a very long, active life doing exactly this work, planning for continuity matters too.

Chetna Sinha: Let me separate the two. Succession at the bank is genuinely challenging, because our headquarters sit in Mhaswad, and it isn't easy to find bankers willing to be based here. The bank has its own CEO and board — as a cooperative bank, the board rotates every five years — and we've been deliberately preparing our next CEO, someone who's been with us 20

years, who'll likely take over within the next year or two. We've built out a full leadership structure underneath — chief audit officer, chief financial officer, chief investment officer, deputy CEOs — and equally important is succession on the board side. There, I've taken something of a hybrid approach: some board members are community leaders themselves, while others are people based in Mumbai who are genuinely passionate about the mission but can't relocate to Mhaswad — including a former HSBC professional who's now on our board. That's the overall succession plan for the bank, and my own exit plan is largely built around it.

For the Foundation, succession is comparatively easier — my team has been with me for 20, 25 years, and they're well placed to run and manage it. The one real challenge, and I'll be candid about it, is finding people willing to live and work in small towns and villages long-term. My own son has joined the Foundation at my request, and we've had interns — including one who came from Mumbai and simply decided to stay permanently. We run a strong internship programme, drawing students from top institutions in Mumbai, and given that I'm a Yale alumna myself, with my children having studied at Georgetown, Harvard, Johns Hopkins and George Washington, we get interns from similarly strong backgrounds — though most, understandably, don't stay long-term; they come, contribute, and move on.

Neharika Vohra: Looking back across everything you've built, what are one or two things you feel you've done particularly well, and what would you do differently in hindsight?

Chetna Sinha: What I feel I've done well — sitting here in Mhaswad and building an institution like the bank, the radio station, came from a conviction that this drought-prone, shepherd-community area, despite everything, has an incredibly rich culture — writers like Venkatesh Madgulkar had written about it in Marathi. I felt this region's identity shouldn't simply be reduced to drought; it needed to stand for something more. Today, "Mann Desh" has genuinely become the area's identity — women from here now go to Mumbai and proudly say they're from Mann Desh, the place where this bank started. Shifting that identity from drought to a rich, living culture is something I'm genuinely proud of.

As for what I'd do differently — there are certainly things. I still think of that woman who came so courageously to tell us her husband had run away, and I feel we should have built out proper debt counselling immediately at that time, rather than being held back by our own fear around NPAs. Another example: a woman named Nakusa — the name itself means "unwanted" — took a loan from the bank to buy property, and became genuinely proud to have her name on the property papers. We've since designed a product offering a reduced interest rate for women who purchase property in their own name, but I don't think we've ever really cracked that as a movement for women's property ownership at the scale it deserves — something we'd actually piloted much earlier, back when I was in Bodh Gaya, before setting up the bank. It's something that's always stayed with me.

Neharika Vohra: Maybe you'll find that solution yet. As we close — I'm sure listeners of many different backgrounds are tuning in, but for a young finance graduate, a management student, or anyone wanting to work in rural development, women's entrepreneurship or financial inclusion, what two or three things should they keep in mind?

Chetna Sinha: First, I'd tell young people: you'll often have genuinely great ideas, especially around others who tell you it won't work — believe in it anyway; it can work. When we were setting up the bank, everyone in Mumbai told me I was crazy. But when I spoke with the village women, their response was simply, of course we can do this. So listen to your own heart — if something feels right to you, pursue it.

Second, especially in rural development, remember that knowledge doesn't sit only with you. There's an enormous amount of knowledge already present in villages that we too often fail to take seriously. Approach people as equals, and you'll find they're often willing to share things you'll feel lucky to have heard — their knowledge, in many respects, runs well ahead of ours; I've seen that firsthand, repeatedly. And I think it's genuinely exciting that young people today, largely free of certain older biases and comfortable with technology, can bring native intelligence and artificial intelligence together in ways that could create real wonders.

Neharika Vohra: Thank you so much — you carry so much wisdom yourself. If I had to distil it, the three words I keep hearing from you are listen, learn, and respect — and that's really where everything else follows from. This has been such a powerful conversation. I wish we had more time to hear all your stories, but thank you so much for your time and the generosity with which you've shared your experiences. We wish you, and every woman you're touching through this work, all the very best. Thank you.